Shimon Peres was the last of Israel's founding fathers, the men who were present at the creation in 1948, when David Ben-Gurion proclaimed a Jewish state in Palestine. His political career went on to span more than half a century. As the master of ceremonies read a list of his roles in public service, it sounded like he was calling the roll of the entire Israeli government, from premier and president to transportation minister and leader of the opposition. Above all, though, he was Israel's elder statesman, a once-controversial politician who achieved something close to universal respect later in life. He stayed active in politics until almost the last of his ninety-three years. In 2007, when an octogenarian Peres ran for Israel's ceremonial presidency, critics wondered if he was too old for the job. "Don't worry," he quipped. "I won't forget to die."

He had a few health scares after his term ended, including a heart attack in January 2016, but at times it seemed he might break his promise. He kept an active schedule, meeting regularly with Israelis and Palestinians, and with world leaders on his frequent trips abroad. On the afternoon of 13 September, however, he suffered a stroke. The prognosis initially looked grim, but surprisingly his condition stabilized overnight, and aides began talking about a recovery. Two weeks later, though, he took another turn for the worse. Doctors said he had suffered organ failure and irreversible brain damage. His family was summoned to Sheba Medical Center in Tel Aviv. Old friends, like Labor leader Isaac Herzog, came to his bedside to say their goodbyes. His children announced his death in the early hours of 28 September. As dawn broke it was, in Prime Minister Netanyahu's words, "the first day that the state of Israel has existed without Shimon Peres."

In Jewish tradition, the dead are buried on the same day. Peres' family made an exception, to allow foreign dignitaries time to arrive. His body was taken to Jerusalem on 29 September, where it lay in state on the stone plaza in front of the Knesset. Tens of thousands of Israelis came to pay their respects, with the twelve-hour viewing period extended until 11 pm to accommodate the crowds. They wept, they lit candles, they took selfies. (A few Israeli journalists complained about the lack of decorum, but Peres, a technophile who had signed up for Snapchat on his 93rd birthday, probably would not have minded.)

The next morning, a Friday, he made his final journey to Mount Herzl, the site of Israel's national cemetery. He was laid to rest between two of his oldest rivals: Yitzhak Rabin, who had fought him for decades over control